



There is a comforting assumption that lies beneath much of modern management consulting.

If an organizational model has been successful in London, New York or Amsterdam, it should be equally successful in Dubai, Riyadh or Sharjah. The logic appears unassailable. Good management is good management. Best practice is, after all, called *best* because it has demonstrated its effectiveness elsewhere. Consultants travel the world carrying frameworks, governance models and organizational designs that promise to transform institutions by replicating proven approaches.

Over the course of my career, I have come to believe that this assumption is only half true.

The challenge is seldom identifying world-class management practice. The real challenge lies in ensuring that those practices acquire meaning within the social, institutional and cultural realities



of the organizations expected to implement them. Organizational transformation is therefore not simply a process of transferring knowledge across borders. It is a process of translation.

That lesson became profoundly clear during an engagement with the Sharjah Sports Council in the United Arab Emirates.

Our assignment appeared deceptively straightforward. The Council wanted to professionalize its network of sports clubs by redesigning organizational structures, strengthening governance, introducing modern management systems and creating the conditions necessary for long-term sporting excellence. Football sat at the heart of the programme—not only because it was the region's most popular sport, but because it represented an opportunity to rethink how sport could contribute to youth development, community wellbeing and national aspirations. The ambition extended far beyond winning matches. It sought to build institutions capable of developing people.

At first glance, the solution appeared obvious.

Around the world, professional football organizations had already demonstrated what excellence looked like. European clubs had refined governance structures, performance management systems, academy models and commercial strategies over decades of professional competition. International federations had published frameworks describing how successful sporting organizations should be governed, funded and developed. There was no shortage of best practice to draw upon.

The temptation for any consultant would have been to select the most successful models and reproduce them as faithfully as possible.

We chose a different path.

From the outset, our philosophy was not to import international practice into the Middle East but to interpret it through the realities of the local environment. We deliberately combined international expertise with local experience, recognising that global standards would only create value if they were understood, accepted and enacted within the cultural, institutional and social context of Sharjah. As we described in our final report, our objective was to apply international best



practice "through a cultural lens" to ensure that what was recommended could genuinely be implemented locally.

At the time, I regarded this primarily as good consulting practice.

Today, nearly two decades later, I see it differently.

That engagement marked the beginning of a much deeper intellectual journey. It forced me to confront a question that would eventually shape my doctoral research into organizational transformation: Why do leadership teams, presented with the same strategy, the same structures and the same opportunities for change, respond so differently? Why do some embrace transformation with conviction while others comply reluctantly or quietly resist, even when everyone agrees that change is necessary?

I did not yet have the answer.

But somewhere between the football pitches of Sharjah and the boardrooms I would later study, I began to realise that successful transformation depends on something far deeper than the quality of the management model itself.

It depends on how people make sense of it.

The Universal Game and Local Rules

One of the reasons football provides such a powerful metaphor for organizational transformation is that, on the surface, it appears wonderfully universal.

The dimensions of the pitch are defined. The Laws of the Game are identical whether the match is played in London, Buenos Aires, Tokyo or Dubai. A goal counts the same everywhere. Referees apply the same rules. Coaches study the same tactics. Elite clubs increasingly recruit from the same global talent pool, while advances in sports science, analytics and performance management circulate almost instantly across international leagues. If ever there were a domain where global best practice should transfer seamlessly across borders, football would seem to be it.



Yet anyone who has spent time in the game quickly discovers that football is never just football.

Every nation plays the same game differently because every nation understands the game differently. Brazilian football celebrates creativity and improvisation. German football has long been associated with discipline and systematic execution. Spanish football prizes positional intelligence and technical mastery, while English football has traditionally celebrated tempo, physical commitment and directness. The rules remain constant, but the interpretation of those rules produces remarkably different expressions of excellence. The world's greatest football cultures have not emerged by copying one another. They have emerged by adapting universal principles to local histories, identities and aspirations.

Organizations are remarkably similar.

Management literature often presents organizational models as though they exist independently of the societies within which they operate. Governance frameworks, organizational structures, leadership competencies and performance systems are frequently described as universal solutions that can be implemented wherever the need arises. While these models undoubtedly embody valuable principles, they rarely arrive in culturally neutral form. They reflect assumptions about authority, accountability, decision-making, communication and individual responsibility that have evolved within particular institutional traditions. Those assumptions are often so deeply embedded that they become invisible to those who developed them.

That reality became increasingly apparent as we worked alongside the leadership of the Sharjah Sports Council and its affiliated clubs.

The objective was never to create miniature versions of European football clubs. The Council's strategic vision was rooted in something fundamentally different. It sought to raise athletic standards while simultaneously contributing to youth development, moral values and the broader aspirations of the Emirate. Sporting excellence was inseparable from community development and aligned explicitly with the principles of Islam and national priorities. Football therefore represented only one dimension of a much broader social project.



This distinction mattered enormously.

Many international consulting engagements begin with benchmarking. Consultants identify organisations that perform exceptionally well, analyse the systems that underpin their success and recommend adopting similar practices elsewhere. Benchmarking is valuable because it broadens the range of possibilities available to decision-makers. It demonstrates what can be achieved. However, benchmarking becomes problematic when imitation replaces interpretation.

Our approach deliberately resisted that temptation.

We certainly looked outward. We examined successful sports councils and professional football organisations across Europe, South Africa and Australasia, studying how they developed talent, governed clubs, supported communities and strengthened organizational performance. Those insights shaped our thinking, but they never dictated our recommendations. Instead, they served as reference points that had to be interpreted within the realities of Sharjah's governance structures, community expectations and long-term developmental ambitions.

Looking back, I now recognise that we were practising something I would later come to describe as translation rather than transfer.

Transfer assumes that knowledge can move unchanged from one context to another.

Translation recognises that ideas acquire meaning only when they are interpreted within the beliefs, relationships and institutional realities of the people expected to implement them.

At the time, I regarded this primarily as a matter of cultural sensitivity. It was about respecting local traditions while introducing modern management practices. What I had not yet understood was that the deeper challenge was not cultural adaptation alone.

It was executive interpretation.

The same governance framework could be viewed as an opportunity by one leader and as an unwelcome constraint by another. A new organisational structure could inspire one executive while threatening another's identity or influence. A performance management system might be seen as a



mechanism for developing people or as an instrument of surveillance and control. None of these interpretations resided within the management model itself. They emerged from the people asked to bring that model to life.

That insight would remain only an intuition for many years.

Only later, through my research into organizational transformation, would I begin to understand why identical management models generate remarkably different outcomes—even within the same organization. The answer, I would eventually discover, lies not in the quality of the imported model, but in the worldviews through which leaders interpret it.

Designing for Performance, Leading Through Meaning

As the project unfolded, our attention naturally shifted from understanding the environment to designing the organisation that would thrive within it. Like many transformation initiatives, the work involved developing new governance arrangements, redefining executive roles, introducing performance management systems, creating player services and establishing the organisational capabilities required to support professional football. On paper, these were familiar management challenges. They reflected principles that had been successfully implemented by high-performing sporting organisations around the world. The question was not whether these practices worked. The question was whether they would work here.

One of the guiding ideas behind the programme was deceptively simple.

Organisations achieve sustainable success when four elements reinforce one another: a strong strategic core, sufficient organisational capacity, effective operational capability and the competencies required to execute consistently. These elements formed the backbone of what we called the *SportsWorkx* model—a practical framework designed to translate strategic ambition into organisational performance. Rather than focusing exclusively on success on the field, the model recognised that enduring sporting excellence depended equally on governance, professional management, player development, community engagement and commercial sustainability.

That philosophy shaped every recommendation we made.



The proposed organisation structure was not intended merely to rearrange reporting lines. It was designed to align the Council's strategic objectives with the day-to-day work of clubs throughout Sharjah. Accountability needed to be clarified. Decision-making had to move closer to those engaging directly with players and communities. Information systems were required to improve coordination across clubs. New roles were introduced to strengthen community development, player welfare, marketing, governance and quality assurance. Every structural decision sought to answer a single question: *How do we create an organisation capable of delivering its strategic intent consistently?*



Looking back, I remain convinced that these organisational principles were sound.

In fact, many have since become standard practice across professional sport and beyond. Effective organisations still require clear governance, well-designed roles, integrated information systems, robust performance management and deliberate investment in leadership development. None of those ideas have diminished in importance.

What has changed is my understanding of what they can—and cannot—achieve.



At the time, I believed that if we designed the right structure, created the right processes and developed the right competencies, organisational behaviour would naturally follow. Better systems would produce better execution. Better governance would produce better decisions. Better role clarity would produce greater accountability.

Experience has taught me that reality is considerably more complex.

Two clubs can implement exactly the same organisational structure and experience entirely different outcomes. Two executives can occupy identical positions with identical responsibilities yet lead in profoundly different ways. Even within the same leadership team, some individuals become enthusiastic champions of transformation while others quietly retreat into compliance, despite working within the same structures and being exposed to the same information.

The organisation, in other words, does not change simply because its design changes.

People decide whether the new organisation becomes real.

That distinction became increasingly visible as we worked alongside different clubs. Some leadership teams embraced the proposed changes, viewing them as an opportunity to professionalise their organisations and prepare for the future. Others implemented the visible elements of the programme while continuing to make decisions through established informal practices. In several cases, boards struggled to relinquish operational control to newly appointed chief executives, despite formally endorsing governance arrangements that clearly distinguished strategic oversight from executive management. The organisational chart had changed. The underlying patterns of leadership had not.

At the time, I interpreted these differences largely as implementation challenges. Some clubs required additional coaching. Others needed stronger governance or clearer accountability. Those explanations contained an element of truth, but they did not fully explain what I was observing. Why did leaders, exposed to the same structures, interpret their responsibilities so differently? Why did some see empowerment where others saw a loss of authority? Why did identical organisational interventions produce such different levels of commitment?



Those questions stayed with me long after the project had ended.

It would take another decade—and a doctoral study into executive engagement during organisational transformation—before I realised that the missing variable had never been the management model itself.

It had always been the way leaders interpreted it.

The Missing Dimension of Transformation

For many years, I believed that successful transformation depended on designing better organizations.

If the strategy was clear, the structure aligned, the governance sound and the systems robust, implementation would naturally follow. That belief was hardly unusual. Much of the organizational change literature, and indeed much of management consulting, is built upon the premise that organizations change by redesigning the formal architecture within which people work. Structures are reshaped, processes redesigned, performance measures introduced and leadership competencies developed. Better organizations, we assume, produce better behaviour.

Yet my experience increasingly suggested that something important was missing.

The Sharjah engagement was not unique. As my consulting career expanded across the Middle East and Africa, I encountered remarkably similar patterns in banks, government institutions, family businesses and multinational corporations. Leadership teams invested enormous resources in developing thoughtful strategies and sophisticated transformation programmes. They employed internationally respected consulting firms, benchmarked global best practice and implemented comprehensive change initiatives. Despite this, implementation outcomes varied enormously.

Some executive teams generated extraordinary momentum.

Others appeared committed during workshops but gradually lost energy once implementation began.



Others never openly resisted the transformation at all. They attended meetings, approved plans, completed action items and spoke positively about the future. Yet somehow the organization never really changed. Progress slowed. Difficult decisions were postponed. Old routines quietly re-emerged. Transformation became something people discussed rather than something they enacted.

The more I observed these patterns, the less satisfied I became with the conventional explanations.

We often attribute unsuccessful transformation to poor communication, inadequate leadership, resistance to change or weak project management. While each of these undoubtedly plays an important role, they rarely explain why individuals exposed to the same communication, the same leadership and the same organizational conditions respond so differently.

The answer, I began to suspect, lay beneath observable behaviour.

It lay within the way executives evaluated the transformation itself.

That question ultimately became the focus of my doctoral research.

Over several years, I studied a large-scale digital transformation within a multinational African banking institution. Like the football project in Sharjah, the organization possessed a clear strategy, experienced leadership and significant institutional support for change. Yet executives who were exposed to the same strategic vision developed markedly different patterns of engagement over time. Some became increasingly committed to the transformation. Others complied symbolically without investing themselves fully. Still others gradually disengaged despite never openly opposing the programme.

What fascinated me was that these differences could not be explained simply by personality, organizational position or technical competence.

Instead, they reflected something much deeper.

I came to understand that before executives decide what they will do during transformation, they first decide what the transformation means.



They evaluate whether it is legitimate. They decide whether they feel personally responsible for advancing it. They assess whether they possess sufficient influence to shape its outcome. These judgements occur long before visible behaviour emerges, quietly shaping every subsequent decision an executive makes.

This insight led me to conceptualise what I now describe as Executive Worldviews—deep evaluative structures through which leaders interpret organizational change. Unlike attitudes, opinions or momentary emotions, worldviews provide the enduring lens through which executives answer three fundamental questions.

Is this transformation the right thing to do?

Do I feel personally obligated to support it?

Can I genuinely influence whether it succeeds?

Looking back, I realised these questions had been present throughout my consulting career.

They were present in the boardrooms of Sharjah, even though I lacked the language to describe them.

When some club leaders enthusiastically embraced professionalisation while others quietly reverted to traditional ways of operating, they were not simply responding to a new organizational structure. They were interpreting its legitimacy. They were weighing its implications for their responsibilities. They were judging whether they possessed the agency to make it succeed within their own clubs.

The organizational design was identical.

The interpretations were not.

That realization fundamentally changed the way I think about organizational transformation.

Today, I no longer see strategy, organization design and change management as separate disciplines. They are different stages within a much deeper process of executive interpretation.



Organizations certainly require effective structures, governance and systems, but those interventions only become transformational when leaders collectively construct a shared understanding of why the future matters and what their role is in bringing it into existence.

Transformation, I have come to believe, succeeds long before implementation begins.

It succeeds when executive judgement begins to align.

From Executive Alignment to Executive Navigation

If my doctoral research explained *why* executives respond differently to the same transformation, it also forced me to confront a far more practical question.

What should leaders actually do about it?

For decades, organizational transformation has been managed through familiar interventions. We communicate the vision more effectively. We develop stakeholder engagement plans. We redesign structures, introduce new governance mechanisms and invest in leadership development. These remain important. They address many of the visible barriers to change. Yet they also share an important assumption—that if leaders understand the strategy, they will naturally commit to it.

My experience suggests otherwise.

Understanding is not the same as conviction.

Executives can fully understand the commercial rationale for a transformation while remaining unconvinced that it represents the right future for the organization. They may intellectually support the strategy yet feel little personal responsibility for driving it. Others may passionately believe in the direction of change but quietly doubt whether they possess sufficient authority or influence to make a meaningful contribution. In each case, implementation begins to fragment long before any behavioural differences become visible.

This realization led to the development of what I now call the Worldview Levels of Activation (Worldview LOA) Framework.



The framework emerged not as another change management methodology, but as an attempt to make visible the evaluative processes that executives bring to every transformation. Rather than focusing primarily on what leaders do, the framework seeks to understand how they interpret the change they are being asked to lead. It proposes that sustained executive engagement depends upon the degree to which three deep evaluative dimensions become aligned over time: the perceived legitimacy of the transformation, the executive's sense of relational obligation to advance it, and the belief that they possess sufficient agency to influence its success.

Looking back at the Sharjah project, I often find myself imagining how differently the engagement might have unfolded had this framework existed then.

We invested considerable effort in translating international best practice into locally appropriate organizational solutions. We worked carefully with boards, chief executives and club officials to ensure that governance arrangements respected local traditions while supporting professional management. We developed structures that balanced strategic oversight with local autonomy. We designed systems intended to strengthen accountability without undermining community relationships.

Today, however, I would begin somewhere else entirely.

Before discussing structures, governance or performance management, I would want to understand how each member of the leadership team interpreted the transformation itself. Did they genuinely believe that professionalisation strengthened rather than threatened the identity of their club? Did they view the proposed governance model as enhancing stewardship or diminishing long-established authority? Did they experience the transformation as an opportunity to serve their communities more effectively, or as an externally imposed management initiative? Most importantly, did they believe they possessed the influence necessary to shape the future they were being asked to create?

These are not questions that can be answered by reviewing an organizational chart.

They are questions about executive judgement.



To support these conversations, I developed the Executive Sextant.

The name is deliberate. Long before GPS, navigators crossing unfamiliar oceans relied upon a sextant to establish their position before determining where to sail. The instrument did not choose the destination, nor did it chart the route. It simply answered the most fundamental question in navigation: *Where am I now?* Without that position fix, even the most accurate charts became significantly less useful.

Organizational transformation demands exactly the same discipline.

Before executives can align around a shared future, they must first understand the assumptions, beliefs and judgements that shape how each of them currently interprets that future. The Executive Sextant provides that position fix. It helps leadership teams surface differences in legitimacy beliefs, relational obligation and perceived agency before those differences silently undermine implementation. Rather than waiting for resistance, compliance or disengagement to become visible months later, leaders can address divergent interpretations while strategy is still being formed.

In many respects, this represents the natural evolution of my consulting philosophy.

Earlier in my career, I believed my role was to help organizations design better systems. The Sharjah engagement taught me that those systems needed to be translated into local contexts rather than imported unchanged. My doctoral research extended that insight further by demonstrating that even locally translated systems remain insufficient unless executives themselves develop a shared interpretation of what the transformation means.

Successful transformation, therefore, is not simply the product of good strategy, effective organization design or excellent change management.

It is the outcome of leaders learning to navigate together before they begin the journey.

The Future of Global Consulting



The consulting profession has become exceptionally good at discovering and disseminating best practice. Every year, thousands of organizations benchmark the world's highest performers, adopt internationally recognised governance frameworks and implement management systems that have proven successful elsewhere. There is enormous value in this. The cumulative knowledge generated over decades of research and practice has transformed organizations across every sector imaginable. The challenge is no longer finding good ideas. The challenge is ensuring that those ideas become meaningful within the organizations expected to implement them.

Looking back, I no longer see the Sharjah Sports Council engagement simply as a sports transformation project. I see it as one of the defining moments in my own development as a consultant. At the time, I believed our greatest contribution lay in translating international best practice into a locally appropriate organizational model. We resisted the temptation to copy Western institutions and instead sought to design a system that reflected the aspirations, governance traditions and social realities of Sharjah. I remain convinced that this was the right approach.

What I did not yet appreciate was that translation occurs at more than one level.

Management ideas must first be translated into the cultural and institutional context within which an organization operates. But they must also be translated into the minds of the executives responsible for bringing those ideas to life. A strategy can be perfectly adapted to its environment and still fail if the people leading it attach fundamentally different meanings to what it represents. Organizational transformation is therefore not simply a process of organizational design; it is a process of executive interpretation.

This realization has fundamentally reshaped the way I think about consulting.

Today, I see successful transformation as requiring three interconnected forms of alignment. The first is strategic alignment—a shared understanding of where the organization is going and why. The second is organizational alignment—creating the governance, structures, capabilities and systems necessary to support that direction. The third is executive alignment—ensuring that those



responsible for leading the transformation collectively view it as legitimate, feel personally obligated to advance it and believe they possess the agency to influence its success.

The first two forms of alignment have long been the focus of management consulting.

The third remains largely invisible.

Yet it is often the decisive factor separating organizations that merely launch transformation programmes from those that genuinely transform. Organizations do not implement strategy. Organizational charts do not create commitment. Governance frameworks do not inspire action. People do. More specifically, executives do. And executives never implement strategy exactly as it is written. They implement the strategy they believe is worth pursuing, the strategy they feel responsible for advancing and the strategy they believe they can influence.

That, perhaps, is the most enduring lesson I have carried from a football transformation project in Sharjah to boardrooms, executive teams and my own doctoral research.

Changing organizations is never simply about changing structures.

It is about changing the way leaders see those structures, the future they represent and their place within that future.

The future of global consulting, therefore, will not belong to those who become better at exporting the world's best management models. It will belong to those who become better at helping leaders translate those models into convictions worth acting upon. Because transformation begins long before organizations change.

It begins when executives begin to see the future through the same lens.